

The picket fence

NRIs return to the safety net of home, cushioned by the plush comforts of their American lives

NRI HOUSING

Bangalore | KARNATAKA



■ By Stephen David

Vijay Bobba 45, formerly of Silicon Valley, is relaxing with his cup of cappuccino, admiring the lush lawns outside his elegant four-bedroom villa. The landscaped driveway, the white picket fence, the arched entrance, the cobbled pathway, the 24/7 security, the outrageously expensive live-in domestic help—it's like being home in the San Francisco Bay area. There are not even any power outages in the area. Bobba can hardly believe his luck at the soft landing in India thanks to Prestige Ozone. Dominated by NRIs, Ozone is a gated community of 200-odd villas spread over 50 acre near the International Tech Park in Whitefield, east of Bangalore. More than 20 acre have been left wide open by Ozone owner Irfan Razack for the extra lung space and greenery that foreign returnees like. Spread over 4,000 sq ft, each self-contained villa costs around Rs 3 crore and they have all been sold out.

Tech-entrepreneur Bobba, who studied in Georgia State in Atlanta and the University of California at Berkeley, lived in the US for 20 years before coming home for good with his wife, Padmaja, 42, a financial consultant with Oracle, and two young sons. He is one of the 50,000 Indian techies who have come back to India for good in the past seven years from the US, according to a Nasscom report. "This place is as good as Boston or Menlo Park in California," Bobba says, "and gave us a perfect soft landing. There are so many of us from the US in this block that I sometimes wish I had my venture fund meetings in the community itself." Like some of his other friends from the Valley who have come back home, Bobba says with the country's booming economy set to grow around 10 per cent, India is a great market for wealth creation. "I always wanted to be in entrepreneurship and plunged into it, leveraging the environment at Silicon Valley." He does not miss his home in Palo Alto, California, but the three years in India so far have been an exciting journey for Bobba, now the CEO of a marketing company. With the latest gizmos and broadband in hand, technology has also shrunk distances with fellow techies from the US just a shout away in the shock-absorbing Ozone layer.

Far from the maddening chaos of downtown Bangalore, the Whitefield community is a good hideout, offering the peace and quiet of Menlo Park or Mountain Gate, and the sometimes rocky, but always romantic, comforts of being home.

GIREESH G V



FRESH START: Bobba with his wife Padmaja at Whitefield